Chapter 4 – Alexander the Great

In ancient Macedonia, 6,000 kilometers (4,000 miles) away from the Indian subcontinent, a ruler unlike any other came to power. History remembers him as Alexander the Great, the young emperor who spread Greek culture to half the world at the tip of his sword. In 326 BCE, the conqueror set his sights on the Indus River Valley after coming fresh off a successful campaign in Persia. It was a somewhat metaphorical challenge since Alexander wished to rule over the entire known world—maps of the ancient Greeks and Macedonians only went as far out as the Arabian Sea.

In the 4th century BCE, India was populated by the mixed people of both Dravidian and Aryan ancestry, whose political groups were numerous throughout the landscape. Though the people shared a basic culture, they were organized into a multitude of small kingdoms and city-states; there was no de facto leader of the land. For a would-be conqueror, this only made the job simpler as he could effectively march upon each successive polity and defeat one after the other without facing the backlash of an all-powerful ruler with armies the size of his own.

With 45,000 soldiers, Alexander faced his next colonial enemy at the east side of the Indus River. Prepared with the best ships, he planned to navigate down the Indus westward, crossing into the first urban settlement he found there, at Taxila. Alexander's troops easily won the quick surrender of Taxila without so much as a battle, whereupon several Macedonian commanders were left in charge of the town while the army marched southward. Being of Greek descent, the Macedonian army was exceptionally skilled at seafaring, but this particular conquest called for extensive overland ventures. There were 160 kilometers (100 miles) between the Indus and the Hydaspes Rivers; the emperor bade his troops to deconstruct their boats and carry the pieces to the next waterway. In this fashion, the journey between rivers took two months, including deconstruction and reconstruction time. On the other side of the Hydaspes awaited the kingdom of Porus.

King Porus was a famous and fierce ruler of the lands between the Hydaspes and Acesines Rivers, a region now called Punjab. He was over six feet tall, a marked aberration of height and size in that time and place, and a fearsome warrior on his feet or astride an elephant. Porus did not deign to allow the Macedonians to rule his kingdom without earning that right and so he mustered his own army to try to defeat them. It was a